

ment trust had a large position in only one stock—a “blue chip.” And that was on the short side!*

When he died, it was wisely decided to wind up the affairs of the corporation. But the surviving officers could not wind it up quickly enough to avoid making an additional fortune with each week’s delay.

IT WASN’T STOLEN—YOU LOST IT!

I am aware that for the last quarter-hour someone in the gallery has been—well, let us say verging on rudeness. You, sir—yes you, the gentleman who has been flourishing the umbrella—will you take the floor and tell us your objections so that we all can hear? . . .

Er, well, ah, hrmp. Yes, I should have taken up that subject earlier. Your point, which is expressed so vigorously, is that Wall Street men are not such dunces at all; that they are crooks and thieves and very clever ones to boot; that they sell for millions what they know is worthless; that, in short, they are villains, not children.

That is certainly a widespread point of view. People would rather believe that they have been robbed than that they have been fools on the advice of fools.

I am even tempted to think that Wall Street men themselves encourage this idea. Faced with explaining the huge losses “investors” have suffered, they subconsciously feel that it is better to be regarded as a Machiavelli than as one who has spent his adult life engaged in mumbo-jumbo.

I defer to no man on a knowledge of how money is stolen in Wall Street. If the popular demand is sufficient, I shall explain in my next lecture how to steal an eighth (\$12.50) and also a million dollars (two points on the underwriting of

* Nearly all investment trusts forbid themselves ever to take a short position, but this was a brilliant exception. It had a comparatively small number of stockholders.